Paying for Youngstown State: Two Family Pathways

Crown Roots Foundation · Financial aid, scholarship stacking, and the YSU Foundation

For: Crown Roots families and Crown Roots mentors
Figures: YSU's own Financial Aid Estimator, 2026-27, run October 2026 for a Pennsylvania student living on campus. These are estimates, not offers. Your family's numbers will be different, but the way the money stacks stays the same.

Start Here: The Same Bill for Everyone

Every Pennsylvania student living on campus at YSU starts from the same cost of attendance (2026-27):

Cost	Per year
Tuition and fees	$12,077
Housing and food	$12,484
Direct charges (on the YSU bill)	**$24,561**

Books	$1,290
Transportation	$2,320
Personal	$1,988
Other	$888
Full cost of attendance	**$31,047**

A Pennsylvania student pays only **$360 a year** more in tuition than an Ohio student.

The two numbers that matter:

- **What's on the bill:** direct charges ($24,561) minus grants and scholarships.
- **Full net price:** full cost of attendance ($31,047) minus grants and scholarships. This is the real cost of the year, including books and travel.

How the Money Stacks at YSU

Layer	What it is	How to get it	Need-based?
1. Pell Grant	Federal grant, up to $7,395	FAFSA	Yes

2. FSEOG	Federal grant for the lowest incomes	FAFSA	Yes
3. PA State Grant	Up to $600 at YSU (Ohio school)	FAFSA by May 1, plus PHEAA State Grant Form	Yes
4. YSU PA Grant Match	YSU matches the PA grant at 200%, up to $1,200	Automatic with the PA grant	Follows the PA grant
5. Scholarships for Excellence	Merit, $1,000 to $5,000 by GPA and SAT	Apply to YSU with transcripts by **February 15**	No
6. Housing Grant	$2,000, living on campus	Separate application, first come, first served	No
7. YSU Foundation	1,100+ scholarships, $500 and up, $11M+ a year	One application by **February 1**	Some are, many aren't
8. Honors College and department awards	Extra awards for Honors and specific majors	Honors application; department contacts	Mostly no

9. Outside scholarships	Local, regional, state, national	Each one separately	Varies
10. Work-study or campus job	Earned, paid to the student	FAFSA and job search	Work-study is
11. Loans	Borrowed, repaid with interest	Accept only what's left	Last resort

YSU's rules, written in Ohio law (Ohio Admin. Code 3356-8-10):

- Total aid can't go over the full cost of attendance.
- If extra money comes in, **YSU reduces loans first**, before scholarships.
- If aid is more than the direct charges, **the student can get a refund** for books, travel, and personal costs.

Layers 1 to 4 depend on income. Layers 5 to 9 depend on effort. That's the whole conversation with any family.

YSU merit awards (Scholarships for Excellence)

Award	Per year	With SAT	Test-optional
First Opportunity	$1,000	3.0 GPA, 990 SAT	3.0 to 3.49 GPA

Red and White	$2,000	3.0 GPA, 1110 SAT	3.5 to 3.89 GPA
Deans'	$3,000	3.5 GPA, 1220 SAT	3.9 GPA and up
President's	$4,000	3.5 GPA, 1290 SAT	Not available
Trustees'	$5,000	Valedictorian	Not available

One award per student. Renews with a 3.0 GPA in college.

Pathway A: Family Income Under $75,000

Example family: household of five, $56,000 income, student with a 3.5 GPA and 1110 SAT, living on campus.

Step 1: What YSU's calculator gives

Grant	Amount
Pell Grant	$7,395
FSEOG	$400

PA State Grant	$600
YSU PA Grant Match	$1,200
Scholarship for Excellence (Red and White)	$2,000
Housing Grant	$2,000
Total	**$13,595**

On the YSU bill	**$10,966**
Full net price	**$17,452**

Step 2: Close the bill with effort

About **$11,000 a year** more takes the bill to $0. One way it can add up (an illustration, not a promise):

Source	Example
Higher merit tier (SAT 1220 instead of 1110)	+$1,000
YSU Foundation: 4 awards averaging $1,500	+$6,000
Local scholarships: 4 awards averaging $1,000	+$4,000
Added	**$11,000**
On the bill	**about $0**

Step 3: The refund zone

Once total aid is more than $24,561, the extra comes back to the student, up to the $31,047 cost of attendance. That's up to **$6,486** for books, travel, and personal costs. This is how three students we've worked with paid nearly $0 for YSU engineering, and how one was paid to attend.

What to watch

- **Apply for the Housing Grant early.** It runs out.
- **Report every outside scholarship.** At YSU it reduces loans first.
- **Refile the FAFSA every year.** Pell, FSEOG, and the PA grant are renewed one year at a time.

- **Compare honestly:** in Pennsylvania, this family gets up to $6,000 from the PA State Grant instead of $600, and Pitt-Johnstown's tuition pledge makes tuition $0 at incomes of $75,000 or less. YSU wins when the Foundation and outside scholarships come through, and on programs and fit.

Pathway B: Family Income Over $75,000

Example family: household of four, $95,000 income, same student (3.5 GPA, 1110 SAT), living on campus.

Step 1: What YSU's calculator gives

Grant	Amount
Pell Grant	$900
FSEOG	$0
PA State Grant	$600
YSU PA Grant Match	$1,200
Scholarship for Excellence (Red and White)	$2,000
Housing Grant	$2,000

Total	**$6,700**

On the YSU bill **$17,861**

Full net price **$24,347**

At this income, Pell and the PA grant may be small or zero depending on family size and assets. Treat the first four layers as a bonus, not the plan.

Step 2: Effort carries more of the weight

Merit, Foundation, and outside scholarships don't care about income. For this family they're most of the plan.

Source	Example
Higher merit tier (SAT 1290 with 3.5 GPA: President's)	+$2,000
YSU Foundation: 4 awards averaging $1,500	+$6,000
Local scholarships: 5 awards averaging $1,000	+$5,000

Added	**$13,000**
On the bill	**about $4,861**

Step 3: Cover what's left without heavy debt

Option	About how much
Campus job, 10 hours a week	$3,000 to $4,000 a year
Summer job savings	Varies
529 or family savings	Varies
Federal Direct Loan (student)	Up to $5,500 the first year, only if needed
Avoid: Parent PLUS loans	This is the parent's debt, with higher fees

What to watch

- **Still file the FAFSA.** Many YSU Foundation scholarships, the PA grant and match, and federal loans need it. The 2027-28 form takes about 15 minutes.

- **The test score matters more here.** Moving from a 1110 to a 1290 SAT with a 3.5 GPA doubles the merit award (from $2,000 to $4,000), every year for four years.
- **Honors College:** 3.5 GPA and 1240 SAT (or 26 ACT), separate application. Ask about Honors awards and housing.
- **Income dropped?** If the family's income is lower now than on the tax year the FAFSA uses (job loss, divorce, medical bills), ask YSU Financial Aid for a special circumstances review.
- **Do not file as independent to hide parent income.** Working and paying taxes doesn't make a student under 24 independent. A false answer can mean paying aid back.
- **Compare honestly:** over $75,000, Pitt's tuition pledge no longer applies, and Pennsylvania state schools offer less grant aid at this income. YSU's low out-of-state price and large Foundation often make it one of the strongest options for this family.

Side by Side

	Under $75K	Over $75K
Starting bill	$24,561	$24,561
Grants from income (Pell, FSEOG, PA grant and match)	$9,595	$2,700
Merit and Housing Grant	$4,000	$4,000

On the bill after YSU's calculator	**$10,966**	**$17,861**
Full net price	**$17,452**	**$24,347**
Effort needed to reach $0 on the bill	about $11,000 a year	about $18,000 a year
Realistic target	$0, with a possible refund	A few thousand, covered by work and savings
Biggest lever	Foundation and local scholarships	Test score, Foundation, and local scholarships

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The Four-Year View

- **Merit renews** with a 3.0 GPA. Keep grades up from day one.
- **Reapply to the YSU Foundation every year.** Continuing students can win awards tied to their major.
- **Refile the FAFSA every year,** by May 1 for the PA grant.
- **Keep applying to outside scholarships in college.** Fewer students do, so the odds get better.
- `[TO CONFIRM WITH YSU]` whether the Housing Grant renews after the first year.

Talking With Families: Crown Roots Mentor Notes

Start from the need-based number, then move in either direction:

1. Run YSU's calculator with the family's real numbers. That's the need-based starting point (layers 1 to 4).
2. Show what effort adds (layers 5 to 9): a better test score, the Foundation application, local scholarships.
3. Show what's left and how to cover it, from refund (below the bill) to work and savings (above it).

TRUE: "Your income decides where you start. Your effort decides where you finish."

FALSE: "You'll go for free."

THE TALKING POINT: "Students like you have gotten to nearly $0 by applying early and widely. Here's the plan."

Key Dates

Date	What
Fall of senior year	File the FAFSA (2027-28 opened Sept 24, 2026)
As early as possible	YSU Housing Grant application
February 1	YSU Foundation scholarship application

February 15	Apply to YSU with transcripts for Scholarships for Excellence
May 1	FAFSA deadline for the PA State Grant, plus the State Grant Form

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Sources: YSU Financial Aid Estimator (2026-27, runs of Oct 8 and Oct 16, 2026); YSU Scholarships for Excellence and Scholarship Opportunities pages; Ohio Admin. Code 3356-8-10. Scholarship examples are illustrations. Figures change every year.